

South Korea: Acceleration in Early June Exports, Boosting the Trade Surplus to a Record high

Bottom line:

Korea's per-workday exports in the first 20 days of June rose 8.7% mom sa, accelerating from 3.1% the prior month. Total exports during the 20 days increased 5.7% mom sa, driven by broad-based gains across major products. Exports to EM Asia led the gains, with exports to Singapore, Malaysia and Taiwan accounting for two-thirds of the headline increase. Total imports increased 3.1%, and the trade surplus (not seasonally adjusted) widened to a historical high of US\$17.5bn from US\$11.5bn the prior month.

Key numbers:

June 20 days' exports, adjusted for workday differences: +8.7% mom sa vs. previous: +3.1% mom sa

June 20 days' imports, adjusted for workday differences: +7.9% mom sa vs. previous: -1.6% mom sa

June 20 days' trade balance: +US\$17.5bn vs. previous: +US\$11.5bn

Main points:

1. Korea's per-workday exports in the first 20 days of June rose 8.7% mom sa, accelerating from 3.1% the prior month ([Exhibit 1](#)). Total exports during the 20 days increased 5.7% mom sa, sustaining a robust pace of increase after rising 9.8% the prior month. On a year-on-year basis, total exports during the 20 days grew 60.4%, moderating slightly from 64.7% the prior month.

2. Exports increased broadly across major products. While semiconductor exports grew 2.0% mom sa, sustaining a 9-month streak of increase albeit at a moderated momentum from 11.9% the prior month, other tech exports accelerated sharply to 17.1%, driven by sharp gains in exports of computers and household appliances. Non-tech exports rose 4.8%, up from 3.1% the prior month, helped by broad pick-up in momentum across autos, machinery, petroleum and ships.

3. Exports to EM Asia led the gains. In particular, exports to Singapore and Malaysia rose sharply by 98.4% and 59.0% respectively, while exports to Taiwan increased at a robust pace of 11.1%. The three destinations together accounted for roughly two-thirds of the headline sequential increase. Exports to mainland China and Japan gained around 2%, and exports to the US increased 3.6%.

4. Total imports increased 3.1%, slowing from 5.4% the previous month. Around half of the headline sequential increase was accounted for by a rebound in imports of

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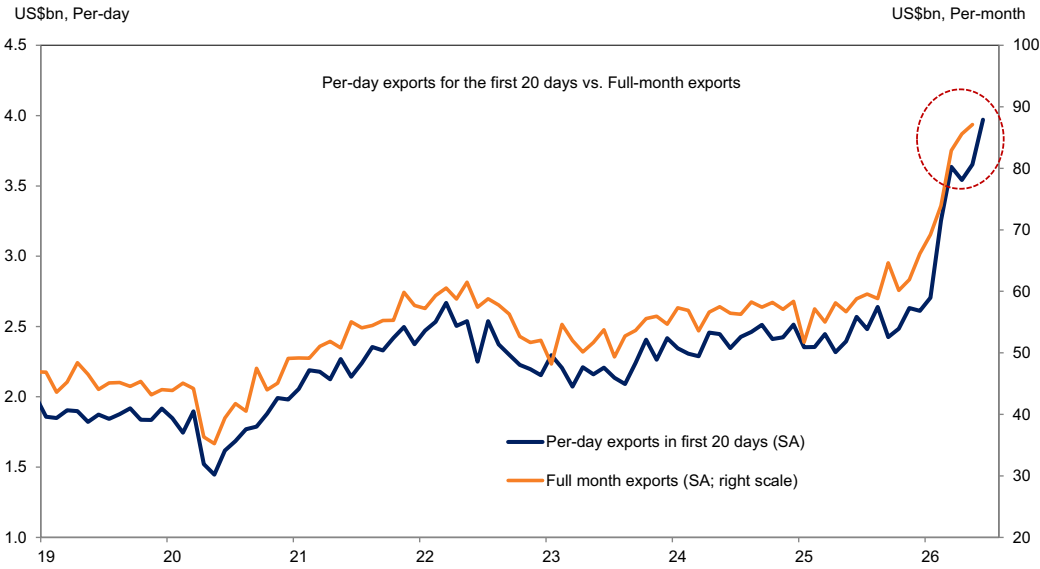
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tech products (semiconductors and handsets). Imports of energy products slowed, weighed down by a contraction in petroleum products, and imports of machinery also moderated. The trade surplus (not seasonally adjusted) widened to a historical high of US\$17.5bn from US\$11.5bn the prior month.

Exhibit 1: Acceleration in early June exports



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Reg AC

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